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Literacy Learning as Social Practice
Warner School for Education
University of Rochester
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- 1. Unit Context:** As a student pursuing teaching certification, I plan to eventually teach Social Studies and TESOL at the Highschool level. While I am new to teaching, I will begin my in person residency soon and will likely end up in Greece which is a suburban district, is predominantly white, with many pockets of low income earners making the class incredibly economically diverse, some students may be facing economic hardships and food insecurity. I've designed this unit for a 9th Grade AP Social Studies Class. I expect many of the students to be high achievers, prepared for a greater workload, however these students are more likely to be susceptible to burnout and anxiety related issues as is common in high pressure, high performance individuals. This is something I would need to be cognizant of in my instruction. Statistically speaking, my class is likely majority female as well.
- 2. Unit Description and Purpose:** The purpose of this unit is to educate students on women in the medieval era (500C.E.-1500C.E.), broader cultural values, and to challenge preconceived notions of sex and gender during this time in history. Over the course of multiple weeks students will learn about several influential medieval women from different geographic, racial, social, religious, class, and political backgrounds who all overcame adversity and challenged the archetype of the Medieval "damsel". Students will further be encouraged to stretch their thinking and explore why history has previously engaged in reductionist views of these women and medieval women in general. The class will be encouraged to discuss the relationship between sex and power dynamics in history, and to explore the extent to which these issues are still prevalent today.
- 3. Literacies Framework:** The literacies which are embodied in this unit are the same outlined in the framework by Gholdy Muhammad which include Identity, Skills, Intellect, Criticality, and Joy.

Identity: Students will have the opportunity to identify more with a population which historically has been underrepresented, and who when documented are often wrongfully vilified on the basis of their sex. Students will get to witness achievements of social mobility, overcoming adversity, and great humanitarian efforts in these figures, as well as many controversial decisions as well. They will be shown everything, the good, bad, and ugly. This offers students an opportunity to connect with these figures from the past on a

human level and gives a more holistic view of history as students are reminded that they are reading the records of real lives.

Skills: Students will practice research based skills and navigation of academic databases.

Intellect: Students will learn about multiple different cultures at a common point in time and how common threads weave historic events and people together. Further, they will be able to begin to recognize patterns as historic events unfold which help to connect similar events through different points in time.

Criticality: Students will consider why women's roles and impact have historically been minimized to "damsel", and what role sex plays in power structures both in the past as well as today, as well as how they can overcome these barriers.

Joy: Students will engage in creative writing historical fiction assignments of their choosing, either a play or story, or other mode, starring a historic medieval woman at its center during true events in her life, which allows them to engage in fun and creative ways with their research while simultaneously, gaining a deeper level of understanding and empathy for her humanity as they place themselves "in her head" and consider her thoughts, feelings, and motivations.

4. Lesson Plans:

Teacher: Valerie Prindle		Grade Level: AP 9th Grade History
Unit Name: Dismantling the Damsel, the True Lives of Medieval Women		
Length of Unit: 4 weeks: 20 lessons (1 hour per lesson)		
Week 1	Lesson 1: Coming to curiosity; What is a Damsel? Exploring Popular depictions: Students will explore popular literary figures of archetypical medieval damsels in arthurian legend, mythology, and fairytales, students will be encouraged to explore how these depictions impact modern	Homework: Students will be required to watch the linked documentary on the Arthurian Character Morgan Le Fay: Morgan le Fay: The (not so) Evil Sorceress of Arthurian Literature (youtube.com) Students will begin to consider which Medieval

	understanding of medieval women • The instruction will include a brief history of the Victorian revival of Arthurian fantasy, and how Victorian sensibilities were then imposed upon previous texts and these ideas were adopted by 19th and early 20th century historians and authors. • The setup for the unit will be explained to the class, at this point their writing assignment will also be handed out.	woman they would like to present on, topic pending teacher approval to prevent repeats at presentation week. (Not one of the women covered in class)
	Lesson 2: Going back to Byzantium, the early Medieval era; Empress Theodora:  • Presentation of Theodora's life from "Actress" (Prostitute) to Empress • Theodora's Feminism and Activism through her legislation • Students will be encouraged	Homework: Listen to the For the Love of History Podcast on Theodora: https://open.spotify.com/episode/3SN3NzZr1L2gG5uZ3OwhV6?si=9EicTo86QTGFV1VVmRuN6A

	to ask questions, and engage in critical debate and theory over presented information	
	Lesson 3: Concerning Chinese Controversies; Empress Wu Zetian:  ● Presentation of Wu Zeitan's life from peasant, to courtesan (to two Emperors!), to Empress, and then to ruling as Empress in her own right ● Discussion of controversies surrounding Wu Zetian including the multiple murders and the deaths of her children ● Discussion of the positive legislation the she passed and especially what she did for women's rights in China ● Invite students to discuss and debate the dichotomy and intersectionality of Wu Zetian's two identities (As controversial figure, and humanitarian leader)	Homework: Listen to the For the Love of History Podcast Episode about Wu Zetian: https://open.spotify.com/episode/1zPyo30xmMCcxfw1Gj0dcP?si=qr5S262tSemUEyxNM8HS1w

	Lesson 4: Updates: • The class will confirm presentation topics for the final week of the unit to ensure there are no repeats. Finding Common Ground: • Students will be broken off into discussion groups and asked to consider the following questions ○ What do Empress Theodora and Empress Wu Zetian have in common? ○ What do their commonalities suggest about the universalities across different cultures at this point in history? ○ What do their stories suggest about the pathway to power available to women in the Early Medieval Era? Do you feel the vilifications of these women by past historians is justified? Why or why not? • Students will come back together to discuss theories and findings as a class.	Homework: Begin independent research for and work on presentation and creative writing assignments.
	Lesson 5: Addressing the Elephant in the room; Prostitution and Child Sex Trafficking in the Early Medieval Era: • With great sensitivity to the topic and many reassurances	Homework: Watch your favorite Disney movie or comfort classic! This was a sad class.

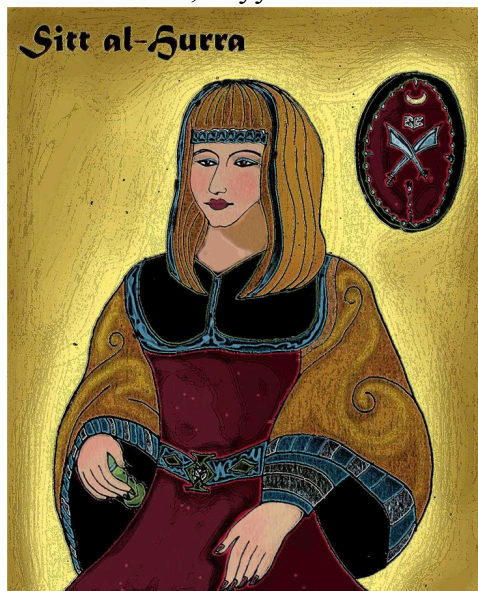
	that I am an available resource if my students need me we would begin class. ● Students will be handed a printed copy of this History Today article Inside the Medieval Brothel and given quiet time to read and comprehend it, we will then discuss as a class ● Ask students to share their thoughts of what they read, students are encouraged to ask any questions they may have. Students will be encouraged to reflect on the statement that accounts of the lives of prostitutes were given to us almost exclusively through elite male observers and asked to consider how that may affect how the narrative of these women was shared through the historic record. ● Students will be encouraged to consider that medieval women of low rank and wealth were often forced by circumstance into prostitution and that the industry then puts her in an oppressed and marginalized position. Remind the class that women like Theodora and Wu were extraordinary exceptions to the rule, as social mobility was nearly impossible for most women in this situation. Ask students to consider that this is still true for many sex workers today. ● For a little levity at the end of class the last few minutes will be spent watching Horrible Histories Historic Wife Swap	
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Week 2	Lesson 6: The Reason You're All Here; Fatima Al-Fihri:  • The class will be spent exploring the life of Fatima Al-Fihri from her early days as religious refugee to her establishment of the world's first university • The class is encouraged to ask questions, and make comments as they come to the students minds	Homework: Continue research for and work on presentations and creative writing assignments.
	Lesson 7: Fatima's Legacy, Higher Education and the Rise of Medieval Universities: • The class will spend the first part of the period collectively listening to the BBC In Our Time Episode on Medieval Universities • Together, how does Fatima's contribution and the later additions of other medieval Scholars still impact us today? How have things changed?	
	Lesson 8: "Get thee to a convent!" A Woman's Path to Education in Medieval Europe: • This lesson will cover	

convents and abbeys and similar education paths for individuals without means or money for private tutoring and how tightly woven religion was into all aspects of Medieval society. Students will be given a few minutes for private reading of the linked History.com [article](#) on women's education in the medieval era

Lesson 9:

The Pirate Queen of the Mediterranean; Sayyida Al-Hurra:



- This lesson will focus on the turbulent life of Sayyida Al-Hurra who was forced to flee her home in Granada Spain as a refugee during the Reconquista and eventually took up a life of piracy to fight against her enemies, her partnership with the infamous Pirate Barbarossa, to her active part in the reconstruction of historic

	Islamic cities and her marriage to the king of Morocco. - Students will be encouraged to ask questions, comment, and engage in instruction. Lesson 10: The Islamic Golden Age and the Spanish Reconquista:  - This lesson will focus instruction on the Islamic Golden Age, its dichotomy in comparison to the relative dark ages facing Europe in proximate history, and the events that led up to the Spanish Reconquista as well as the immediate and long term implications - Students will be asked to consider social justice issues of the time such as religious freedom, islamophobia, refugees, and women's rights, how do we draw parallels to today?	
Week 3	Lesson 11: The She-Wolf of France; Queen Isabella:	Homework: Continue research for and work on presentations and creative writing assignments.



- This lesson focuses on the life of Queen Isabella, her marriage to King Edward II at 12 years old, her struggles to gain influence away from the king's "favorites" and the abuses she suffered as a result, through her coming into her power and eventual revolt and later invasion and coup of England where she assumed power as Queen Regent until her son Edward III came of age
- Ask students to consider what it meant for women to be used as leverage in bargaining political deals, to further discuss what the vilification of Isabella as "She-Wolf" means in terms of what is perceived as a woman's role, and what it means for women's power when the men in their lives

do not support them.

Lesson 12:

Women at war:

- Students will be given printed copies of the following text and granted in class time to read: (Verbruggen, J. F. "Women in Medieval Armies." Chapter. In *Journal of Medieval Military History*, edited by Clifford J. Rogers, Kelly Devries, and John France, 119–36. Boydell & Brewer, 2006.)
- Afterwards, as a class we will discuss ways in which our thinking has been challenged by what we have learned about the roles women played in medieval warfare, defense, and military strategy.

Lesson 13:

Women in business, Masterclass Merchants:



- This lesson will focus on

	instruction into medieval businesses and the roles the women played, the ways in which they conformed to society and the ways in which they defied it through their work.	
	Lesson 14: Terry Jones Medieval Lives; The Damsel: • The class will watch the Terry Jones Medieval Lives Documentary Episode on the Damsel • Students will be asked to reflect on the unit as a whole, what have we learned? What was surprising? What changed about what we think of women of the past and about people of the past in general? How will you take these lessons forward to challenge other stereotypes you encounter?	
	Lesson 15: Resource Period: • In recognition of the various socio-economic situations of the class, students will be granted in class time to access the library and other school resources for their assignments due the following week. This is an opportunity for students to ask the teacher final questions they may have or seek assistance.	
Week 4	Lessons 16-20:	Homework:

	Student Presentations: Students will have 10 minutes each to present what they have learned about their chosen Medieval Woman, how they defy the stereotypical damsel and what lasting mark they left on history. An additional 5 minutes will be budgeted between each presentation for peer questions and turnover/setup of presentation materials allowing all 20 students to present in the span of 5 1 hour lessons.	None, relax!
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5. Create a Sample:

Sample Presentation: [Link](#)

Sample Creative Writing Assignment: [Link](#)

6. Unit Reflection:

Interestingly enough, for me personally this assignment was the most enjoyable. I had a lot of fun with the hours spent researching the various historical events and figures covered in the materials and drawing meaningful connections between them. It's important to me that I convey the complex and nuanced nature of historic events and lives to avoid giving an over simplified version of events and allow students to develop the ability to recognize patterns and understand how events and cultures develop, interact, and interplay with one another. I also firmly believe that this is a transferable skill to understanding modern geopolitical issues.

Often at the K-12 levels instruction on the medieval era is heavily focused on the male players with little or no mention of important or influential women, and often if they are mentioned it is only in association to their husbands. Instruction of the Medieval era also usually focuses on exclusively European narratives, excluding Middle Eastern, Asian, and North African experiences which were not isolated from Europe or from the natural and cultural movements of the time. Too often at the K-12 level is the medieval experience taught as an intellectually bleak, patriarchally oppressive, rat infested, shit

covered, exclusively white catholic experience. This is not only factually misleading, but it does a disservice to the lived experience of the people of the time.

In designing this unit, I wanted to dispel these misconceptions by focusing on Medieval women and “deconstruct the damsel”. I included figures from Asia, the Middle East, North Africa, and Europe to expand my students' understanding of what constitutes the medieval stage. I also focused greatly on power dynamics and offered ways the class could explore how each of these women exercised her power within her role and left lasting marks on history. Some examples include Empress Theodora who's legislation still influences legal codes today, or Fatima Al-Fihri who established the first university and created the overall concept of higher education which would inspire every single academic institution to follow.

I think one of the most challenging aspects of designing this unit plan was in limiting myself to a set amount of content. Given that the medieval era covers a span of approximately 1,000 years I could easily spend the whole year teaching just medieval history. But of course we have other content in the curriculum that needs to be covered. I needed to give general enough instruction to have touched on multiple aspects of the era and give students the resources they need to understand the overall concept, but I didn't want to be so overly generalized that students felt detached from it or risk historic figures appearing to come across more like characters than people. One of my overarching goals in this unit was to humanize history.

In attempting to achieve this goal, I opted to focus on a few select women of diverse backgrounds to highlight their experiences and impact and then to explore more general societal and cultural issues. Particularly I focused on social justice issues that were prevalent during the time and explored with the class how understanding these issues helps us to understand social justice issues today. This engages students in Literacy practices of criticality and encourages them to take on a participatory role. Further, I encourage students to take on the role of instructor the last week of classes as each student educates their peers on the medieval woman they chose to cover and through their creative writing projects have the opportunity to humanize them.

Through this mini unit assignment, I had the opportunity to see multiple ways in which I can creatively engage my students' different literacy skills. With the integration of multimodal mediums, like articles, journals, documentaries, podcasts, and books I'm able to better connect with students who may not learn best through traditional methods. Also, by allowing students several weeks to complete their assignments, I am able to stress the importance of quality of content. I used to believe that Literacy was a person's ability to read and write well and at length in a given language. While writing skills are certainly important, I've learned that these can be cultivated through practice and I've since rethought my concept of Literacy. I now believe Literacy to be a person's ability to communicate and comprehend complex concepts, practices, and systems. These permeate

all aspects of society and I can cultivate these by offering diverse and interesting instruction, particularly of typically untold stories.

By focusing on telling untold stories, I am committing myself to an equity aligned framework, and I am incredibly proud to be part of that. I hope to inspire my students through my instruction to see history for what it is, a record of the lives of real humans doing the best they can and achieving great things. I want them to take these lessons into their own lives and encourage them to pursue passions and dreams they otherwise may not have.